For a while she just stared at me, without uttering a word. And then she broke her silence. ‘Go home.’ I returned a rather confused and questioning stare. ‘I said . . . go home. NOW!’ she ordered strictly. I could see that she meant what she said, and I could feel her anger. But the episode was about to start, and I was reluctant, so I didn’t move. ‘Go home, Gunjan Saxena,’ she said for a third time. Maa never repeated anything—ever. If she asked for something and we didn’t do it, she would never ask again. But she had asked me to go home, thrice now. There was no way I wasn’t going to comply, however reluctant I was. Helpless tears trickled down my face and I stomped away from the ante room angrily. Maa followed me. I ran straight to my room and fell on my bed. By this time, I was sobbing loudly. Maa stood at my room’s entrance. It pained her heart to see me cry, but she stuck to being strict.

‘Finish your homework now and be prepared to submit the notebook by Monday. Until then, you do not get to go out of this room,’ she said and walked away. It only added to my frustration and I lay on the bed, crying. The brimming well of tears dried up after a while, and, besides, I had accepted my fate. Maa came in with a glass of warm milk after half an hour. I didn’t look at her—I was still angry. She sat by my side as I scribbled in my notebook. She could see my eyes were still swollen and red. Her hand slowly reached for my face, but I looked away and she pulled it back. She opened the notebook and started to go through its contents. For the rest of the night, I did my pending homework and Maa helped me. Neither of us slept until four in the morning. The next two days were no different. We didn’t speak about anything other than my homework. Maa kept bringing the meals and other things I needed to my room, and I kept scribbling. I would cry in between, whenever my hand hurt from all the writing. Maa would write on my behalf for a while then. But she didn’t excuse me at all. Eventually, on Monday morning, my homework notebook was ready. ‘Promise me you will confess to Ms Meenakshi that you lied, and you will assure her you won’t lie again,’ Maa said to me as I walked out of the house for school. I didn’t turn to look at her. Dada tried to explain to me why Maa had been so strict. The previous year, when Dada had told a lie about